

Becoming a Bricoleur

Leading with what you have — memory, tools, and people already in the room.

Solve unprecedented problems with what's already here — not with the perfect plan you don't have yet. Five practices. One 60-second forage.

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Human Mode, Always.

The meeting that waited for perfect resources

You have been in the room.

The problem is real. The timeline is short. Someone says — not unkindly — that you cannot move until headcount lands, until the vendor is chosen, until the data is complete, until the budget cycle turns.

So the room waits.

Not because there is nothing to work with. Because the room has been trained to treat *missing ideal conditions* as a stop sign. The people at the table have already solved stranger problems in other lives — and none of that is invited into the conversation.

That invitation is the skill.

Bricolage is adaptive resourcefulness: creating solutions from whatever is at hand rather than waiting for ideal conditions. In leadership, it is foraging your full human portfolio under pressure — and turning what you find into a rough, usable next move.

What a Bricoleur is (and isn't)

A Bricoleur is...	A Bricoleur is not...
A skillful forager of lived experience	A scrounger who never asks for real resources when needed
Someone who recombines tools and people at hand	Someone who glorifies underfunding as virtue
Comfortable shipping a rough artifact	Someone who performs scrappiness for show
Curious: <i>who have I known who solved something like this?</i>	Someone who only trusts best practice from elsewhere

The engineer waits for the right materials and the clean plan. The Bricoleur starts with the materials already on the table — including the human ones — and builds something that can be tested *today*. Most hard problems need both. The failure mode is waiting for ideal and under-foraging what you already have.

The three materials

Before you escalate the gap list, inventory these three.

1. Lived memory

People you have known. Roles you have held. Failures that taught you a shape. The grandmother who negotiated scarcity. The former boss who held a room. The child who asked the obvious question adults stopped asking.

2. Tools at hand

Software already licensed. Half-built process. A junior with data. A partner who owes you a favor. A template someone abandoned that still has one good page.

3. Constraints as design input

Time, money, and politics are not only obstacles. They are design parameters. A constraint forces combination. Combination is the Bricoleur's craft.

PRACTICE 1 · STATION DIGITAL TWIN

The 60-Second Memory Forage

When: you are stuck, or the room is waiting for conditions that will not arrive this week.

1. Name the challenge in one sentence.
2. Set a **60-second** timer.
3. Close your eyes. Summon a specific person — grandmother, former boss, mentor, child, colleague from another industry.
4. Ask: *How would they solve this with what they had?*
5. Write the first usable move — not the perfect plan.

Why it works: It pulls non-work (and prior-work) intelligence into a problem framed as “no resources.” Most of what you need is not missing. It is uninvited.

Do this week: Run the forage once before you send a “blocked on budget” note.

Anti-pattern: Treating the forage as nostalgia. The output is a next move, not a story.

PRACTICE 2

Inventory the room before the gap list

When: the first slide of the meeting is “what we need.”

Flip the order for ten minutes: people already here → tools already paid for → prior scraps → *then* true gaps.

Before we name what we don’t have, let’s name what we do — including who in this room has solved a cousin of this problem somewhere else.

Do this week: Open one planning meeting with inventory, not the wish list.

Anti-pattern: Inventory as performative optimism. Be specific — names, tools, artifacts.

PRACTICE 3

Two odd tools, one problem

When: the team is stuck in a single-domain frame.

Force a recombination: pick the stuck problem, name two tools or disciplines that “don’t belong” together, ask what a solution looks like if both must show up. End with: *what will we try in 48 hours?*

Do this week: One forced pairing in a real decision.

PRACTICE 4

Rough artifact in 24 hours

When: the group is polishing a deck before testing anything.

We don't need the finished version. We need a rough artifact by tomorrow that can be wrong in public.

Smallest true teacher: one-page prototype · five calls with the same three questions · one ugly scenario model · one-week pilot with one team.

Do this week: Ship one rough artifact before the next “we need more research” loop.

Anti-pattern: Rough as excuse for low standards. Rough means early and testable, not careless.

PRACTICE 5

Debrief: what did you forage that you almost ignored?

When: after a win, a miss, or a scramble — 10 minutes.

1. What did we use that was already here?
2. What memory or person changed the approach?
3. What did we almost dismiss as “not professional enough”?
4. What will we inventory first next time?

Do this week: Add the debrief to one project retro. Celebrate foraging, not overwork.

Anti-patterns

Anti-pattern	What it sounds like	Better move
Ideal-conditions waiting	“We'll start when we have X.”	Memory Forage + rough artifact this week
Performative scrappiness	“We ship chaos and call it culture.”	Constraints as design, not identity theater
Specialist silo	“That's not how we do it in our function.”	Two odd tools, one problem
Refusing real asks	“Bricolage means never resource the team.”	Forage first; then make the specific ask

Bricolage is not a license to under-invest forever. It is a method for **starting** when the map is incomplete — and for learning what is truly missing.

Your 30-day loop

Week	Focus
1	Run the 60-Second Memory Forage three times on live stuck points
2	Open one meeting with room inventory before the gap list
3	Force one “two odd tools” recombination + 48-hour try
4	Ship one rough artifact; debrief what you almost ignored

Go deeper

- **Human Mode Hub** — free assessments and field guides
- **Reading the Room** — Emotional Aperture Measure
- **Competent Humility** — Pulse Check + Confident & Humble field guide
- **Quiet Understanding** — the hard moment, sixty seconds
- *Human Mode* (HarperCollins, 2027) — Part II at full length

You do not need ideal conditions to begin.

You need a forage, a recombination, and a rough artifact.

The leader who waits for perfect resources will be late to the only moment that mattered. The leader who forages becomes a Bricoleur.

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